

CHAPTER 22 — The Death Warrant

By nine on Monday morning, the lock-up no longer belonged to them.

Blue lights moved across the corrugated doors.

A uniformed officer stood beneath the security camera while another spoke to the storage manager beside the damaged lock. White scene tape crossed the entrance to the unit. Reyes remained inside, beyond the false shadow, the camp bed and the nail in the wall.

Voss watched from the passenger seat of a car parked two streets away.

Vale sat behind the wheel.

Neither had slept.

The radio played quietly because silence had begun to resemble the lock-up.

A local news presenter discussed roadworks, school closures and a council dispute over waste collection. Ordinary problems arranged into five-minute segments.

Vale switched it off.

"You called them," Voss said.

"Yes."

"You could have waited."

"For what?"

"Someone to open the unit during business hours."

"And let him remain there until then."

"He would not have noticed."

Vale looked through the windscreen.

The answer was true.

That did not improve it.

She had made the anonymous emergency call from well away from the lock-up shortly after three.

Break-in. Possible injured man. Storage row behind the tyre depot.

No names.

No explanation.

Enough for the emergency services to find him before the day began.

They had removed only what connected Reyes directly to the contract: the spare operational charger, a folded route sheet, a duplicate access key and the emergency envelope containing cash under one of his aliases.

His wallet remained.

So did the bracelet.

His body would acquire an official name.

The work would not.

Vale rested both hands on the steering wheel.

The blue lights continued moving across the storage doors.

Reyes's bracelet remained on his wrist.

Red, yellow and blue thread. Uneven knots. One letter bead trapped upside down near the clasp.

Vale had seen him wear it through years of work and had never asked where it came from.

Voss removed his glasses and cleaned them with a folded handkerchief despite the lenses being clear.

Reyes had carried three coffees into the lay-by on Friday and remembered how everyone took them.

That was not absolution.

It was a fact belonging to the same man who had entered the lock-up alone.

People were rarely consistent enough to make grief easy.

Vale started the engine.

"Mac will call."

"He already has."

She looked at him.

Voss held up the operational handset.

Four missed calls.

Two messages.

STATUS.

Then:

ANSWER THE PHONE.

No reference to Reyes.

No question about whether he was alive.

Vale put the car into gear.

"Not here."

They drove thirty miles before stopping.

The place was a service station built beside an older road and abandoned by everything except lorry drivers, a vending-machine company and a woman who ran the café because her father had opened it in 1978 and apparently never given permission for the decade to change.

Voss chose a table near the rear wall.

Vale bought tea.

No coffee.

She placed one mug in front of him and sat opposite.

The operational handset lay between them inside a signal-shielding pouch.

Voss looked at it.

"Before we call, define the position."

"We withdraw."

"That is the action. Define the position."

Vale removed the lid from her tea.

"We are no longer acting under Mac's recovery contract. We do not pursue the girl. We do not assist anyone Mac sends after her."

"Neutral."

"No."

Voss waited.

"Neutral means we leave with what we know and allow the next team to work without interference."

"That may be the safest option."

"For us."

"Yes."

Vale looked towards the café window.

A fuel tanker crossed the forecourt and stopped beside the underground tanks. The driver climbed down, checked the area and placed warning cones before opening anything.

Procedure before action.

Reyes had known that.

"He killed Reyes," Voss said.

"Reyes entered alone."

"That does not remove the other man's responsibility."

"No."

"You seem determined to remove ours."

Vale looked back at him.

"I told Reyes not to breach."

"So did I."

"We knew he might."

"Yes."

"We kept him on the operation because he was useful."

"Yes."

"We saw what the town did to him."

Voss's expression did not change.

Vale continued.

"He believed the girl made him look incompetent. We treated that as irritation. Elias treated it as a predictive variable."

"You are admiring him."

"I am describing why Reyes is dead."

"Careful."

"With what?"

"Confusing accuracy with sympathy."

Vale drank the tea.

It was weak.

She put it down.

"I do not sympathise with a man who builds rooms to kill people."

“Good.”

“I also do not believe Mac hired us to recover a wayward niece from an unstable driver.”

Voss looked at the pouch.

“No.”

“He knew the brief was not the whole story.”

“We know the fee did not match the description.”

“Yes.”

“We know he expected independent pressure from Cain’s people and still described Elias as a driver.”

“Yes.”

“We know the folder and storage device matter more than the girl’s welfare.”

“We infer that.”

“We know Reyes is dead because the target was materially different from the brief.”

Voss turned the tea mug by its handle.

Mac’s money had already reached the holding account.

Half had been paid on acceptance.

The remainder was contingent on confirmed recovery.

The contract specified recovery of Zoe alive, return of all associated property, and discretionary neutralisation of Elias if necessary.

It also stated that Elias was a driver with occasional security experience.

That sentence had become obscene in retrospect.

Voss removed the handset from the pouch.

“Withdrawal first,” he said. “Anything after is separate.”

Vale nodded.

He powered on the phone.

It connected within six seconds.

Mac called before Voss could select the number.

Voss answered.

"Voss."

"Where is Reyes?"

Mac did not ask whether.

Only where.

"Dead."

A pause.

Shorter than grief.

Longer than surprise.

"How?"

"He breached a prepared site alone."

"I asked how."

"The target killed him."

Mac breathed once into the line.

"Where are you?"

"Not relevant."

"It is relevant to me."

"The contract is terminated."

Mac's voice became quieter.

"You do not terminate my contracts."

"The brief was materially false."

"The brief contained everything required to complete the job."

"It described Elias as a driver."

"He drives."

Vale watched Voss's face.

Nothing moved.

That was how she knew the anger had arrived.

"You knew what he had been," Voss said.

"I knew rumours."

"You tracked him before the assignment began. You warned us Cain's people might be operating independently. You paid for three contractors while describing the target as a driver. Whatever you knew, you did not put it in the brief."

"You are building a story around a failed operation," Mac said.

"No. I am identifying the omitted variables."

"Reyes ignored your order."

"Yes."

"That killed him."

"It exposed him."

"The distinction will comfort his family."

Voss looked at Vale.

"Do not mention his family again," Voss said.

Mac allowed the silence to lengthen.

When he spoke again, the anger had been put away.

That was more dangerous.

"What are you asking for?"

"Nothing."

"You have the girl?"

"No."

"The drive?"

"No."

"The folder?"

"No."

"Contact with Elias?"

"No."

Each answer was true.

Voss continued.

"We are withdrawing. The remaining fee stays in the holding account. Release it back or leave it there. I do not care."

"You will."

"No."

"You think walking away makes you uninvolved."

"It makes us unavailable."

"It makes you a liability."

Vale watched a lorry reverse towards the café's delivery door.

The warning beep repeated at exact intervals.

Mac continued.

"You have seen the target. You know the girl is carrying property that does not belong to her. You know where the search has been concentrated. You know enough to sell information."

"We are not selling it."

"That is what liabilities say before someone offers the correct price."

Voss placed one hand flat beside the phone.

"If you send another team without correcting the brief, they will die."

"Then perhaps I will send people who follow instructions."

"That was not Reyes's only error."

"No. His other error was working with people who lost control of him."

Vale looked away.

The sentence found Voss where Mac intended.

He did not answer immediately.

Mac pressed.

"You had three professionals and a child. You lost the child, the evidence and one of the professionals. Do not call me to renegotiate your pride."

"This is not negotiation."

"It is a withdrawal request."

"No," Voss said. "It is notice."

"You are under contract."

"Not anymore."

"You will return everything taken from the site."

"We took nothing belonging to you."

"The operational phone."

"Elias has it."

Another pause.

This one mattered.

Mac had not known.

Voss heard the change in his breathing.

“He took Reyes’s phone?”

“Yes.”

“What was accessible?”

“Names. Recent locations. Contact channels.”

Vale watched Voss.

They had not agreed to disclose that.

Then she understood.

Mac now knew Elias could contact them.

That made any future message less useful as evidence of collusion and more dangerous to intercept.

Voss was creating space before it existed.

Mac said, “Change every channel.”

“Already done.”

“Destroy the devices.”

“Done.”

“Then this conversation is over.”

“No.”

Voss looked through the window at the tanker driver checking each connection before releasing fuel.

“If Elias contacts us, we will decide whether to respond.”

Vale did not move.

Mac’s voice became almost gentle.

“That would be a mistake.”

"Possibly."

"You will not make it twice."

The call ended.

The phone screen returned to the contact list.

Voss powered it down.

He placed it inside the pouch.

Vale waited until the closure sealed.

"You told him."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because if he monitors the dead phone, he now expects contact."

"That makes the phone dangerous."

"It was already dangerous."

"It also tells him we may negotiate."

"Yes."

"You said withdrawal first. Anything after separate."

"It is separate."

Vale studied him. "You had already decided."

"No."

"You decided during the call."

"That is what decisions are for."

The waitress arrived with two plates neither had ordered. Eggs, toast and sausages. Vale looked up. "We didn't—"

"Kitchen made them twice," the woman said.

"Eat or don't."

She placed cutlery between them and left. Voss looked at the plate. Reyes would have eaten both. The thought remained unspoken. Vale picked up one piece of toast. "What do we want from Elias?"

Voss did not answer quickly. That was better than the wrong answer arriving fast. "To stop the contract," he said.

"Mac will replace us."

"Yes."

"So the contract does not stop."

"No."

"We warn Elias."

"Yes."

"And?"

Voss looked at her. "We establish that we have no claim on the girl."

"Good."

"We ask what Mac concealed."

"He may not know."

"Then we establish what he does know."

"And Reyes?"

Voss's hand tightened once around the fork.

"No revenge."

Vale waited.

"No forgiveness either," he added.

"That was not an offer."

"If he expects us to apologise for Reyes entering the room, the meeting ends."

"He will not."

"You sound certain."

"I saw the room."

Vale placed the toast down.

"Elias built a lethal environment. He also left Reyes's wallet and bracelet. He took only the phone. That was not mercy. But it was not humiliation."

Voss looked at the untouched sausages.

"We are evaluating the etiquette of a killing."

"We are deciding whether the killer is capable of an agreement."

"That is not the same question."

"No."

The café door opened.

Cold air entered with two drivers carrying high-visibility jackets over their arms.

Vale lowered her voice.

"If we contact him, the girl must be part of the conversation."

Voss looked up.

"She is thirteen."

"She is the subject of the contract."

"That is exactly why she should not be making operational decisions."

"She already is."

"That does not make it appropriate."

"No. It makes excluding her dishonest."

Voss considered this.

Vale continued.

"We do not separate them. We do not approach her alone. We do not test whether she follows him willingly."

"Why?"

"Because every person before us appears to have called control protection."

Voss looked at her for a long moment.

"And if Elias is doing the same?"

"Then she will tell us without us cornering her."

"You place a great deal of confidence in a child you have seen once."

"I place confidence in the fact that she detected three professionals and changed their route."

"That is ability."

"It is also judgment."

Voss picked up the fork.

The eggs had gone cold around the edges.

"Public place," he said.

"Yes."

"Daylight."

"Yes."

"Multiple exits."

"Yes."

"No direct approach to the girl."

Vale nodded.

"We warn them Mac will replace us. We offer a truce limited to our actions. We exchange only information each side can verify."

“And after?”

“We decide after.”

Voss cut into the cold egg.

“That is not an objective.”

“It is the first honest one we have had.”

By late Monday afternoon, the problem had changed shape.

Sunlight moved across the farmhouse kitchen table.

The notes copied from Reyes’s phone had already been reduced to what Elias and Zoe could actually support.

Voss — patient / likely lead.

Vale — interested / likely records.

Reyes — forward operator. Dead.

Sam — before. Not the same.

The names were useful.

They were not trust.

Reyes’s powered-down operational phone remained sealed inside the signal-blocking pouch.

Elias placed the pouch beside the road map.

Zoe sat opposite with the notebook closed beneath one hand.

“You said nothing today,” she said.

“I said nothing with the phone.”

“That was this morning.”

“Yes.”

“What changed?”

Elias looked at the four lines in her notebook.

"Running gives Mac the schedule."

Zoe waited.

"He sends pressure. We move. He sends more. We move again. Every route ends with him choosing when the next problem arrives."

"So we choose one."

"Yes."

"Voss and Vale are not the real problem."

"No."

"Mac is."

"Yes."

"Cain too."

"Yes."

"Then why meet contractors?"

"Because Mac will replace them if they withdraw. If they have not withdrawn, the meeting tells us. If they have, they may know what comes next."

"And if they want revenge?"

"Then public ground limits what they can do."

"Limits."

"Yes."

Elias unfolded a road map.

He had marked three towns.

One near the coast.

One beside a motorway interchange.

One inland, built around an old market square and railway station.

Zoe recognised the third.

They had not visited it.

“What is there?”

“People.”

“That’s disappointing.”

“Cameras. Cafés. Delivery routes. Pedestrian exits. Two car parks and a bus station.”

“A church?”

“Yes.”

“You always choose places with clocks.”

“Clocks create reasons to look up.”

“That sounds like one of your lessons.”

“It is not.”

“Then it’s free.”

Elias ignored that.

The town lay fifty-eight minutes from the farmhouse by the direct route and nearly ninety by the route he intended to use.

Far enough that the meeting would not identify the refuge.

Close enough to reach without fuel or payment stops.

Zoe studied the map.

“You’re meeting them.”

“If they respond.”

Zoe looked at the map. “You’re taking me.”

It was not a question. Elias folded one corner flat. “No.”

She looked at him. “You stay here.”

"No."

The answer arrived without volume. Elias met her eyes. "This is not a training exercise."

"I know."

"It is not an opportunity to prove anything."

"I know."

"Two professionals may arrive expecting a trap."

"I know."

"Then explain the no."

Zoe placed the needle inside the folded sock. "They are coming because of me."

"They are coming because I killed Reyes."

"Mac hired them for me."

"Yes."

"They were told to recover me."

"Yes."

"And you are going to negotiate what happens next without me."

"I am negotiating whether they continue pursuing us."

"That includes me."

"It includes keeping you alive."

"That is what everyone says."

The sentence landed without force.

It did not need any.

Elias looked towards the window.

Zoe continued.

“Mac bought me to keep me safe. Helen and Brian received me to give me a home. Cain moved me because adults knew what was best. The woman at the airport said Elias was harmless and told me to do what he said.”

“That is not what I am doing.”

“Then don’t make the decision look the same.”

Elias looked back at her.

“You being present changes their deployment.”

“They already know I’m with you.”

“They may use you to control me.”

“They already do.”

“How?”

“You keep choosing around me because you’re frightened they’ll use me.”

The answer was too accurate to dismiss and too incomplete to accept.

Elias placed one finger on the map.

“If you come, you remain in sight.”

“Yes.”

“You do not leave with either of them.”

“I know.”

“You do not respond to any request to move somewhere private.”

“I know.”

“If I say move now?”

“I move.”

“If I tell you we’re leaving and there is time?”

“I ask why.”

"That is the agreement."

"Yes."

Elias sat back.

Zoe folded her arms.

The farmhouse held the quiet between them without resolving it.

Finally, Elias said, "Why do you need to be there?"

"Because I want to hear what they say when they know I can hear it."

That was not tactical.

Not entirely.

It was human.

She had been discussed through doors, files, phone calls and contracts for most of her life. Being present was not a demand for danger.

It was a refusal to remain an object inside another room.

Elias opened the map again.

"You stay beside me."

"Yes."

"If I say move now?"

"I move."

"And if there's time?"

"I ask why."

"You are exhausting."

"You said Sam was too."

The comparison entered the room.

Zoe did not use it as leverage.

She had stated a fact and immediately looked away, as though recognising the cost of it.

Elias tapped the town square.

"We use the farm van until the old quarry road. Second vehicle from there. We enter from the east. No direct route back. If anything changes before the square, we abort."

"What counts as changing?"

"Repeated vehicle. Blocked road. Phone activity. Police concentration without explanation. Anyone arriving at the secondary car before us."

"And the backpack?"

"With you."

"Folder and drive?"

"With you."

Elias did not suggest leaving them at the farmhouse.

The refuge was safe only until someone learned it existed.

The evidence stayed with the person who had carried it out.

Zoe looked at the map.

"What do we tell them?"

"The truth we can afford."

"That sounds like lying."

"It is an incomplete answer."

"That is what adults call lies when they need them to sound useful."

Elias looked at her.

She had used the same line in the car days earlier.

It belonged to them now too.

"We tell them Mac lied," he said. "We tell them Cain is separate. We

tell them the girl they were hired to recover is not Mac's niece and the destination was not family."

"They may already know."

"Then we ask what they know."

"And the drive?"

"We do not open it for them."

"You still haven't opened it."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because connecting an unknown device to the wrong machine can expose everything."

"Or because you're frightened of what it says."

Elias looked at the hard drive through the canvas of the backpack.

"Both can be true."

Zoe nodded.

"Better answer."

At five thirty, Elias left the farmhouse alone.

This time he left a note.

Controlled signal. Back by seven. Quarry route. If I am not back by eight, follow the same fallback as Sunday. Do not turn on any phone.

Zoe read it before he left.

"You wrote where you're going."

"Quarry route covers twelve miles."

"You could have written less."

"You asked for a note."

“I didn’t say make it useful to people searching the kitchen.”

Elias tore off the lower half and rewrote it.

Back by seven. If not, fallback at eight.

Zoe examined the new version.

“Better.”

He travelled in the farm van, changed to the old blue estate beneath the quarry shelter and continued towards a commuter station twenty miles from the selected meeting town.

The station had four platforms, two ticket machines and a car park used by people who left vehicles for days without attracting attention.

Elias parked beneath a broken light.

He carried Reyes’s phone inside the signal-blocking pouch and a cheap digital timer taken from the farmhouse kitchen.

At six fourteen, he crossed the footbridge and entered the public toilets on the far platform.

No one followed.

He selected the end cubicle, closed the door and removed the phone.

The device had not been powered on since the lock-up.

It was a stripped-down operational handset configured without a local screen lock.

Elias powered it up.

The phone searched for network service.

One bar.

Then three.

The old team channels were dead.

One final contact route remained available.

That was enough.

He typed:

TUESDAY. 11:30. CLOCK SQUARE. NORTH CAFÉ. TWO ONLY.

He read it once.

No explanation.

No promise.

No threat.

He sent it.

Then he powered the handset down.

The entire activation had lasted less than a minute.

Any watcher on the old identifier now had a location.

That was the point.

It was not the farmhouse.

It was not the meeting town.

Elias removed the battery and SIM where the handset allowed it, sealed the separated pieces in different pockets and left the cubicle as a train entered the station.

Commuters moved towards the stairs.

He joined the flow without looking back.

The dead handset did not return to the farmhouse.

Long enough.

Forty miles away, Vale's clean handset vibrated inside a signal-blocking pouch.

She and Voss had rented a room above a closed estate office using one of the names Mac did not know.

The room contained two chairs, a desk and blinds that smelled of dust when moved.

They had killed every active team channel after speaking to Mac, but Voss had kept one isolated incoming watch on Reyes's final contact route.

Vale opened the pouch.

One message had arrived through it.

No sender name.

The source identifier belonged to Reyes's phone.

She read the text.

Voss stood behind her.

"TUESDAY," she said. "Eleven thirty. Clock Square. North Café. Two only."

"He selected the town."

"Yes."

"Public."

"Yes."

"He does not state terms."

"No."

Voss took the handset.

He examined the message as though punctuation might reveal weapons.

"There are four towns with a Clock Square within two hours."

"Only one has a North Café."

"Could be deliberately generic."

Vale opened a map on the desk.

The selected town sat between the wider refuge search area and the commuter station where the dead phone had briefly reappeared.

The station was not on a direct route from any known refuge.

"He exposed the device away from where he is staying," she said.

"Expected."

"He included 'two only.' "

"He knows the names."

"Reyes's phone gave him that."

Voss looked at the message again.

"We go."

Vale folded the map.

"Yes."

"No separate approach to the girl."

"No."

"No attempt to recover property."

"No."

"We state withdrawal. We warn about Mac. We ask what he knows."

"And if he refuses?"

"We leave."

Vale looked at him.

"Do we?"

Voss placed the handset back inside the signal-blocking pouch.

The answer took time because Reyes remained inside it.

"Yes," he said.

Vale sealed the pouch.

For the first time since the contract began, the next meeting had not

been ordered by Mac.

That did not make it safe.

It made the danger belong to all of them.